

IK 519: Introduction to Indian classical music

Course Code	IK 519
Course Name	Introduction to Indian classical music
L-T-P-C	2-0-2-3
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	B.Tech/MTech/MS/Msc/PhD
Mutual Exclusion	There are no equivalent or overlapping courses across schools.
Approval	61st BoA (Jan 2026); 48th Senate (Mar 2026), in the MA Music and Musopathology curriculum

Preamble

This course offers a holistic foundation for understanding, experiencing, and engaging with the living traditions of Indian classical music. It familiarizes students with essential technical terms, the rāga system, major musical forms, and the contributions of renowned Vāgēyakāra-s and composers. Emphasis is placed on exploring the rich aesthetic values, philosophical ideas, and cultural principles that shape musical expression in both the Karnātak and Hindustāni systems. Drawing from Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS), the course highlights how music in India evolved through oral traditions, pedagogy, spirituality, and community practices. Students will gain the ability to listen analytically, appreciate performance nuances, and understand the conceptual frameworks that continue to sustain Indian classical music as a timeless and dynamic art form.

Course Modules

- **Unit 1: Technical Terms in Indian Classical Music:** Nāda, Śruti, and Svara, Rāga, stāyi, Ārohanam and Avarōhana, Tāla (6 Hours)
- **Unit 2: The Melodic System of Rāga in Indian Classical Music:** Concept and foundations of rāga, rāga lakṣaṇa and identity features, rāga classification, structural principles of rāga, aesthetic dimensions, comparative approaches across Karnātak and Hindustāni traditions. (6 Hours)
- **Unit 3: Structural Musical Forms and Compositional Types in Indian Classical Music:** Karnātak System: Gītam (Abyāsa Gāna), Varṇam, Kṛti, Padam & Jāvali, Tillāna (Sabha Gāna), Hindustāni System: Dhrupad, Khayāl, Tarāna, Thumri, Comparative Study: Compositional Types Across Both Traditions (6 Hours)
- **Unit 4: Eminent contributors to Indian classical music:** Regional and Cultural Influence of the Bhakti Movement on Indian Music. Ālwār-s and Nāyanmār-s, North Indian Bhakti Saints, Purandara Dasa and Annamachārya, Karnātak Music Trinity, Early Hindustani Pioneers. (5 Hours)
- **Unit 5: Musical Instruments of Indian classical music:** Overview of major Karnātak and Hindustāni instruments, covering construction, types, playing techniques, and performance roles; includes melodic instruments (veena, violin, flute, sitar, sarod), rhythmic instruments (mridangam, tabla, pakhavaj), and drone/support instruments (tanpura), providing a foundation in India's classical instrumental heritage. (5 hours)

Laboratory Modules

(14 hours of practical. Practical components are delivered in extended sessions 2 contact hours counted as 1 practical hour)

Practical sessions include teaching svara exercises (Svaravali-s), singing simple musical forms like Gītam-s & Svarajathi-s, Karnātak devotional forms like Tēvaram and Divyaprabhanda-s, and select Hindustani bhajan-s. Guided Music Listing sessions involves the explorations in Karnātak improvisation (Ālāpana, Neraval, Kalpanasvaram, Rāgam-Tānam-Pallavi) and Hindustani forms (Dhrupad, Khayāl, Thumri, Tarāna). Sessions also involve listening and analysis of rāga, tāla, and compositional structures, discussions on Vāgēyakāra-s, and understanding the cultural and historical context of South and North Indian music.

Text Books

1. Sambamurthy. P, *South Indian Music*, Vol: 1-13, Indian Music Publishing House, Madras, 1973
2. Chelladurai P. T, *The Splunder of South Indian Music*, Vaigarai Publishers, 2000.
3. Aadinath Upadhyaya, *Hindustānī Sangīt Gāyan-Sampūrṇ* (title in Devanagari in the source): *Hindustani Music Vocal – Comprehensive*, Kishore Vidhya Nikethen, Varanasi, 2003.

References

1. Seetha s. *Taṇjāvūr as a Seat of Music*. University of Madras, 2001.
2. Gowri Kuppaswamy and Hariharan M. *Music in Indian Royal Kingdoms*. Delhi: B.R. Rhythms, 2015. Print.
3. Brahmaśri Subbarāma Dīkṣita. *Saṅgīta Sampradaya Pradarśini (English)*. Vol. 1, The Music Academy, Chennai, Jan 2011.